Henry Oladele "Dele" Alake

(uh-LAH-kay)

Minister of Solid Minerals
Federal Republic of Nigeria

Addressed as: **Excellency** | Office held since: **August 2023**

Dele Alake, a master communicator turned mining reformer, is leveraging his close relationship with President Tinubu to inject new energy into his portfolio.

- **Unconventional Mining Minister**
  Alake's appointment to the mining ministry raised eyebrows given his non-technical background. He is eager to show that strategic communication skills can be an asset, driving reforms and attracting investment.

- **Tinubu's Right-Hand Man**
  Alake is one of President Bola Ahmed Tinubu's closest confidants, having served under him in Lagos State. Their decades-long relationship is built on mutual trust and a shared vision for Nigeria's development.

His son Olatunbosun, who is the Commissioner for Innovation, Science and Technology in Lagos State, has said that Alake is a disciplinarian who is passionate about education and will debate an issue for hours.

WHY THEY MATTER

Alake is seeking to turn Nigeria into a premier mining investment destination and an engine of President Tinubu's economic agenda.

- **Critical Minerals Apostle**
  Alake is focused on fast-tracking the development of Nigeria's lithium, cobalt, and rare earth deposits through targeted incentives and strategic partnerships. He is focused on value-additions, declaring that "the era of exporting raw solid minerals from Nigeria is over."

- **Institutional Reformer**
  Alake has introduced the Electronic Mining Cadastral System and the Nigeria Minerals Decision Support System to streamline licensing and provide critical data to investors. He secured funding for satellite surveillance to monitor mining sites nationwide, and established a new Nigerian Mining Corporation, which is majority controlled by the private sector.

Alake seems driven to demonstrate to Tinubu that his communication skills and political savvy can translate into technocratic results. In June 2024, he presented refined gold bars to the President, saying the first transaction of the commodity added $5 million to Nigeria's external reserves.

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MEETING WITH THEM

Alake comes off as self-assured in private and public settings, drawing on the rigors of journalism and flair of politics to communicate his points.

- **Setting the Context**
  Alake employs a methodical, professorial speaking style that builds arguments through careful layering of context and evidence. He typically begins by establishing historical or economic context before moving to his main points.

- **Rejecting Unfavorable Premises**
  If confronted with an unwanted topic, Alake rarely loses his cool. He either challenges the questions by posing his own or dismisses the topic entirely. He has called criticisms that he bullies the media "insidious" and "silly" accusations.

Alake frequently draws parallels between current situations and his experience in Lagos State. For instance, when discussing current federal reforms, he often references similar reforms implemented in Lagos under then-Governor Tinubu, using these as proof points for current policies.

ON THEIR MIND

- **Government Rejects Mining Smear Campaign**
  The Nigerian government in mid-March dismissed allegations that it seized a British-developed lithium project and handed it to Chinese operators, describing the claim as false and part of a smear campaign by a mining firm ahead of Tinubu's UK visit.

- **Mine carbon monoxide poisoning**
  At least 37 miners have died from carbon monoxide poisoning at a mining site in central Nigeria, according to a Reuters report in February. The deadly incident, which took place in the Wase area of Plateau State, also resulted in the hospitalisation of 25 people.

- **Economic Gains Threatened by Iran War**
  Nigeria, which only recently cooled inflation from 31.5 percent, is back on alert as the Iran war drives up gasoline and diesel prices. There is growing public pressure to cushion the effects of the rising prices, including by subsidizing the price at the pump.

- **U.S.-Nigerian Tensions**
  President Trump's accusations that Christianity is facing an existential threat in Nigeria and subsequent reports by U.S. lawmakers have roiled relations between the two countries. While it has resulted in closer military cooperation, the government has hired U.S. lobbyists and dispatched senior officials (and the First Lady) to Washington, D.C. to address the allegations.

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NETWORK

Alake is a familiar face in African mining circles, building relationships with counterparts and investors at forums from London to Cape Town to Riyadh. His re-election as Africa Minerals Strategy Group (AMSG) Chairman in January 2026 solidified his position as a leading voice for African mining cooperation

The Minister's relationship with China has deepened following the elevation of China-Zambia ties to a Comprehensive Strategic and Cooperative Partnership. At the Invest in Zambia International Conference 2025, Kabuswe emphasized the visible benefits of this partnership on the ground. Chinese investments remain significant across Zambia's copper belt.

Alake's network reflects his roles as a journalist, activist, politician, and now technocrat—with his decades-long ties to President Tinubu at the center. He is determined to make Nigeria's mining boom a signature achievement of Tinubu's presidency.

Alake is part of Tinubu's inner circle along with other southwestern politicians who worked with the president during his stint as Lagos State Governor. Tinubu has praised Alake for his "candid counseling and unwavering support, which have provided invaluable guidance during challenging times."

CONTROVERSIES

As Alake has moved aggressively to implement his mining agenda and assert federal control, he has ruffled feathers among state governments and entrenched interests.

- **Federal-State Tensions Over Mining Authority**
  Alake's firm stance on federal authority over mineral resources has drawn sustained resistance from state governors. He acknowledged that some governors "feigned ignorance of this constitutional separation of powers" and have taken "outlandish policies"—including banning mining activities or sealing off companies—that conflict with federal jurisdiction.

- **Threats and Backlash Against Reforms**
  Alake has claimed that his enforcement efforts—including license revocations and crackdowns on illegal mining—have provoked threats to his life. He has declared that "no amount of intimidation, sponsored articles by unpatriotic hack writers or campaign of calumny" will deter reforms, accusing affected parties of "employing all forms of tactics, including threats and blackmail to force us to reverse course."

Alake has been criticized for his unbending defense of Tinubu, especially his handling of questions regarding the president's wealth and health during the campaign. In August 2024, he claimed the #EndBadGovernance protests were a plot to illegally topple the government.

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CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **Minister of Solid Minerals**, Federal Republic of Nigeria (2023 to present)
- **Director of Strategic Communication**, Bola Ahmed Tinubu Presidential Campaign (2023)
- **Media Consultant**, Various Companies (2010s)
- **Commissioner for Information and Strategy**, Lagos State Government (1999 to 2007)
- **Pro-Democracy Activist**, National Democratic Coalition (NADECO) (1990s))
- **Editor**, Concord Newspapers (1980s)
- **Principal Current Affairs Officer**, Lagos State Broadcasting Corporation (1980s)

BIO

Alake's journalist and activist background have informed his hard-charging approach to leadership. Alake was born on October 6, 1956 into a family of educators in Aramoko-Ekiti, Ekiti State in southwestern Nigeria.

- **Journalist Credentials**
  Alake attended the elite Christ's School, Ado-Ekiti and later studied political science at the University of Lagos. Alake first made a name for himself as newspaper editor in the 1980s and 90s, using the pen to poke the powerful and champion democracy.

- **Activist Roots**
  Alake's formative experiences include serving as a strategic communicator for M.K.O. Abiola's 1993 presidential campaign and later went into exile in the United States and UK for speaking truth to power under Abacha's dictatorship.

Alake, who speaks English and Yoruba, is married with five children. One of his sons says Alake appreciates "good food." The Minister is a practicing Christian, but he believes that religion should be separate from governance.

NOTES